ABITUR ENGLISH · WRITING

analyse · examine

How to show how a text works – and why

WHAT DO “ANALYSE” AND “EXAMINE” MEAN?

“describe and explain in detail and give evidence from the text, relating the content to relevant aspects of language and form”

Both operators mean the same thing. *analyse* (British) and *analyze* (American) are both correct.

The key: point – evidence – effect

POINT

What does the author do? One topic sentence.

Moreover, her use of language underlines how serious the loss is.

EVIDENCE

Which device? Where? Name it + short quotation or line reference.

The metaphor that each closure “tears another hole in the fabric of our towns” (l. 8)

EFFECT

Why? What it achieves – linked to the task.

… presents the town as something fragile that is being destroyed piece by piece.

Dos and don’ts

DO	DON’T
✓ explain **how** and **why**: point → evidence → effect	× list devices without saying what they achieve
✓ cover **every focus** after *Focus on …*	× leave out a focus area
✓ group your paragraphs by **aspects or functions**	× go through the text line by line
✓ **short quotations** built into your sentences: “…” (l. 8), (ll. 9-11), (cf. l. 12)	× long quotations, *line 8*, German quotation marks „…“
✓ link every paragraph back to the **task**	× retell the content
✓ **simple present**, neutral; narrator ≠ author	× your opinion, *I think*, judging the author

Step by step

Model task: **Analyse how the author conveys her concern about the decline of local bookshops. Focus on communicative strategies and use of language.**

STEP	WHAT TO DO	MODEL TASK (text on page 3)
① Read the task	Underline the **aspect** you have to analyse. Underline **every focus** after *Focus on …*	**Aspect:** how the author conveys her concern. **Focus:** communicative strategies + use of language.
② Collect	Mark devices in the text and note the **line**. Write the **effect** next to each one.	anecdote (ll. 1-4) → sympathy · *we* (l. 4) → responsibility · metaphor (l. 8) → destruction · *where …* (ll. 9-11) → warmth · algorithm (l. 11) → contrast
③ Select and group	Choose the **most important** devices – depth beats quantity. Group them by focus or function, **not** by line order.	¶1 strategies: anecdote, inclusive *we* ¶2 language: metaphor, enumeration, contrast
④ Write	Optional: one opening sentence that answers the task in a nutshell. One paragraph per group: **point** → **evidence** → **effect**. Short conclusion: answer the task, no new devices.	*In her commentary, … conveys her concern mainly by …*
⑤ Check	Every device with evidence **and** effect? Every focus covered? No retelling, no opinion? Simple present?	Both foci covered; every quotation explained.

Typical tasks in the Abitur

- *Analyse the various reasons for the success of Silent Book Clubs. Focus on communicative strategies and use of language.* (2026, gA)
- *Analyse how Lara perceives the various facets of Tom Lake and its surroundings. Focus on use of language.* (2026, gA)
- *Analyse the interaction between Gabriel's parents and Beth, taking into account its effects on the young woman. Focus on narrative situation as well as use of language.* (2026, eA)

→ Every focus after *Focus on …* needs its own part of your answer.

Useful phrases

Opening sentence (optional)	Einleitungssatz (optional)
In the commentary "…", **the author conveys** her concern about … **mainly by** …	Im Kommentar „…" vermittelt die Autorin ihre Sorge über … vor allem durch …
The narrator's feelings become obvious through …	Die Gefühle des Erzählers werden deutlich durch …
Naming a device and giving evidence	**Mittel benennen und belegen**
The author uses / makes use of an anecdote / a metaphor …	Die Autorin verwendet / nutzt eine Anekdote / eine Metapher …
The metaphor "…" (l. 8) … / **This is illustrated by** … (cf. ll. 9-11).	Die Metapher „…" (Z. 8) … / Das wird veranschaulicht durch … (vgl. Z. 9–11).
Explaining the effect	**Die Wirkung erklären**
This emphasises / highlights / underlines …	Das betont / hebt hervor / unterstreicht …
This suggests / implies that …	Das deutet darauf hin / legt nahe, dass …
This creates the impression that … / **This evokes a feeling of** …	Das erweckt den Eindruck, dass … / Das ruft ein Gefühl von … hervor
The reader is thus encouraged to … / **The reader is likely to** …	Der Leser wird so dazu angeregt, … / Der Leser wird wahrscheinlich …
Linking to the task	**Bezug zur Aufgabe**
In this way, the author conveys her concern about …	Auf diese Weise vermittelt die Autorin ihre Sorge über …
This reflects / reveals the narrator's …	Das spiegelt … des Erzählers wider / zeigt …
Moving on and concluding	**Überleiten und abschließen**
To begin with, … / **Moreover**, … / **In addition**, …	Zunächst … / Darüber hinaus … / Zudem …
All in all, the author's use of … **makes** her criticism **very clear**.	Alles in allem macht der Einsatz von … ihre Kritik sehr deutlich.

TOOLBOX: TERMS

USE OF LANGUAGE
word choice (positive/negative connotation), emotive language, register, metaphor, simile, personification, alliteration, repetition, anaphora, enumeration, parallelism, contrast, hyperbole, imagery

NARRATIVE TECHNIQUES (fiction)
first-/third-person narrator, point of view, direct/indirect characterisation, dialogue, interior monologue, setting, atmosphere, symbol, foreshadowing, flashback

COMMUNICATIVE STRATEGIES (non-fiction)
anecdote, personal experience, facts and figures, expert opinion, rhetorical question, inclusive *we*, direct address, appeal to emotions / to logic, irony, call to action

STRUCTURE AND VISUALS
headline, opening, line of argument, contrast, climax, ending, change of tone · photo/cartoon: foreground, caption, symbol and their function in the text

AVOID

× *There is a metaphor in l. 8.*
✓ *The metaphor "…" (l. 8) suggests that …*

× *"tears another hole" (l. 8).* (quotation on its own)
✓ *… describes each closure as tearing "another hole" (l. 8), which …*

× *This shows … This shows … This shows …*
✓ *emphasises · suggests · evokes · reinforces*

× *The author feels lonely.* (first-person narrator)
✓ *The narrator feels lonely.*

Model solution

MODEL TEXT (INVENTED FOR PRACTICE · LEVEL B2/C1)

Closing Time for the High Street Bookshop – commentary by Helen Ward, *The Ashbridge Courier*

When Ruth Carter opened her bookshop in Ashbridge in 1987, there were four others on the same street. Today, hers is the only one left – and next spring, it will close too. Ruth is not giving up because people have stopped reading. She is giving up because we have stopped walking through her door.

We all know the reasons. A paperback costs two pounds less online, and it arrives the next morning without our having to leave the sofa. Convenient? Certainly. But what are we really buying? Across the country, hundreds of independent bookshops have closed in recent years, and each closure tears another hole in the fabric of our towns.

A bookshop is not just a place where books are sold. It is a place where a stranger recommends a novel you would never have chosen, where children sit on the floor and read, where a lonely pensioner finds someone to talk to. An algorithm can tell you what "customers also bought". It cannot ask you how you are.

So the next time you are about to click "Buy now", ask yourself one question: what kind of high street do we want to leave to our children?

Analyse how the author conveys her concern about the decline of local bookshops. Focus on communicative strategies and use of language.

P point EV evidence EF effect · phrases from page 2 in **bold**

OPENING (optional)

In her commentary "Closing Time for the High Street Bookshop", Helen Ward **conveys** her concern about the decline of local bookshops **mainly by** appealing to the readers' emotions and making them feel partly responsible.

PARAGRAPH 1 (communicative strategies)

P **To begin with**, the author uses a personal story and inclusive language to involve the readers. EV She tells them that Ruth Carter's shop is "the only one left" (l. 2) and is about to close. EF This anecdote makes the problem concrete and turns an abstract trend into a personal fate, so the readers are more likely to sympathise with Ruth. EV She then explains that Ruth is giving up because "we have stopped walking through her door" (l. 4). EF By using the inclusive "we", the author makes the readers feel responsible without attacking them directly.

PARAGRAPH 2 (use of language)

P **Moreover**, her use of language underlines how serious the loss is. EV The metaphor that each closure "tears another hole in the fabric of our towns" (l. 8) EF presents the town as something fragile that is being destroyed piece by piece. EV **In addition**, the enumeration of "where" clauses (cf. ll. 9-11) EF **emphasises** what a bookshop offers beyond books and **evokes** a warm, human atmosphere. EV This warm picture contrasts sharply with the "algorithm" (l. 11), which "cannot ask you how you are" (l. 12). EF **In this way, the author conveys** her concern that online shopping cannot replace what a town loses with its bookshop.

CONCLUSION

All in all, the author conveys her concern through a personal story, inclusive language and emotive imagery, which makes the decline of bookshops appear both sad and something the readers themselves can change.

ALSO POSSIBLE – BUT YOU DON'T NEED EVERYTHING

- the rhetorical questions (ll. 6-7, 13-14) and the call to action at the end (cf. l. 13)
- the short question and answer "Convenient? Certainly." (l. 6)
- the structure: from one shop to the whole country to the reader's own decision

→ Two well-explained paragraphs are better than ten devices without effect.